

CHOWBY DIDI HAUS

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What You Never Knew

About JOLLOF RICE

The Smoky Party Jollof, the Chowby Didi Haus way

A RECIPE STORY BY

Chef Blessing Christopher David

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JOLLOF RICE

The smoky party jollof — and the foil-paper secret behind it.

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FROM THE CHEF

A Pot Worth Arguing Over

Every Nigerian has an opinion about jollof rice. It starts friendly arguments at weddings, unites strangers at parties, and turns an ordinary Sunday into a celebration. We defend our pots the way other people defend their football teams.

But here is what most people never learn: that unmistakable *party jollof* aroma — the smoky, deep, slightly charred flavour everyone chases — is not luck, and it is not magic. It is craft. It is patience with the base, respect for the heat, and one humble kitchen trick: a sheet of foil paper.

In this little book I am sharing the way we cook smoky jollof at Chowby Didi Haus — slowly, intentionally, and with love. Cook it once the way it is written here, and you will understand why people keep coming back for that plate.

“If it doesn’t look like art and taste even better, it doesn’t leave my kitchen.”

— Chef Blessing, “the Picasso”

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Three Things You Never Knew

It starts with a dry base, not a wet one

Roasting or steaming the blended tomatoes, peppers and onions until they reduce drives off the raw, sour edge and builds a gentle smokiness — long before the rice ever touches the pot.

The flavour lives in patience

Frying the tomato paste properly takes 30–40 minutes on low heat. Rush this and you taste it. This is where an ordinary pot becomes party jollof.

Foil paper is the secret weapon

A sheet of foil under the lid traps steam and heat evenly, so the rice cooks through without drying out — and sets up that prized smoky bottom layer at the end.

WHAT YOU NEED

Ingredients

A guide, not a law — Chef Blessing cooks by feel, so taste as you go and adjust.

For the smoky base

- Fresh tomatoes (about 8–10)
- Red bell peppers (tatashe)
- Scotch bonnet / ata rodo — to taste
- 3 large onions (for blending) + extra for slicing

For the jollof

- Tomato paste
- Vegetable oil
- Thyme
- Curry powder
- Paprika
- Garlic powder (optional)
- Seasoning cubes & salt
- Chicken stock
- Long-grain parboiled rice
- Foil paper

To serve

- Eggs